

EARLY YEARS MATTER

October 2026 · Family Resource

Transitions Without Tears

Five practical ways to help young children move from one activity to the next while building skills they will use for years to come.

UNDERSTANDING THE BEHAVIOUR

Why can a simple transition feel so hard?

“Time to clean up.” “Let’s put our shoes on.” “It’s time to leave the park.”

For adults, these may sound like simple instructions. For a young child, stopping something enjoyable and shifting attention to something new can be surprisingly difficult.

Transitions ask children to pause what they are doing, hold the next step in mind, manage feelings and move their attention to a new task. These everyday moments give children repeated opportunities to practise important **executive-function skills**.

DEVELOPMENTAL CONNECTION

Executive function helps children manage attention and behaviour as they work toward a goal.

- **Working memory**
- **Self-control**
- **Flexible thinking**

The goal is gradual growth: helping a child learn to stop, shift, remember and regulate with less adult support over time.

FIVE PRACTICAL STRATEGIES

1

Use a timer

A visual or audible timer makes time more concrete. Try: *“When the timer goes off, it will be time to put our shoes on.”*

2

Give a short warning

Try: *“Two more minutes, then it’s time to clean up.”* Keep the warning short and consistent rather than extending it again and again.

3

Build predictable routines

Familiar sequences reduce surprises. For example: **snack → wash hands → shoes → outside.** Over time, the sequence itself becomes a cue.

4

Use “First, Then”

Make the sequence clear: *“First we put the blocks away, then we go outside.”* When appropriate, offer a small choice within the boundary: *“Shoes first or coat first?”*

5

Connect, then be calm and clear

Move closer, use your child’s name and make sure you have their attention before giving the instruction. Eye contact may help some children attend, but it should not be forced. Keep your voice calm and firm: *“It’s time to go. I’ll help you get started.”*

SOMETHING TO REMEMBER

> A child who struggles with transitions is not necessarily refusing to cooperate. Sometimes they are still learning how to stop, shift, remember and regulate.

Those same abilities will later support classroom routines, completing tasks, managing emotions, solving problems and adapting when plans change. Being calm does not mean removing the boundary. Children can experience warmth, support and clear expectations at the same time.

TRY THIS AT HOME

Choose one transition that is regularly difficult this week.

Instead of changing everything at once, choose one consistent strategy and use it for several days. Notice what helps your child understand the transition and participate with a little less support.

1 · Choose
Pick one transition: leaving home, tidy-up, bath time, bedtime or leaving the playground.

2 · Repeat
Use one cue consistently: a timer, two-minute warning, “first, then” or familiar routine.

3 · Notice
Look for small progress: starting the first step, needing fewer reminders or recovering more quickly.

ONE THOUGHT TO TAKE WITH YOU

Small everyday moments are helping to build skills children will use for years to come.

This resource provides general early-years education and is not a substitute for individualized medical, developmental or clinical assessment.